

Online and Offline Networking

Estimated time needed: 5 minutes

Introduction

Networking is essential. It helps you develop and improve your skill set, stay on top of the latest trends in the cybersecurity domain, keep a pulse on the job market, and meet prospective mentors, partners, and clients. You can gain access to the necessary resources to foster your career development.

Objectives

After completing this reading, you will be able to:

- Describe how networking is important to your job search
- List different ways to network online
- Explain how to meet other professionals for networking offline

Networking for job search

The most common way now to search for cybersecurity jobs is to go on job portals or professional networking sites. Many job portals are now available, such as Indeed, LinkedIn, Glassdoor, and Monster. These portals contain millions of listings and make it easier to connect with employers who are looking for your skills and experience. Moreover, job websites offer additional resources for job seekers, such as numerous articles on job search topics as well as blog posts full of helpful tips.

LinkedIn is the top professional social networking site, with 133 million users in the U.S. and more from 200 countries around the world. Eighty-seven percent of recruiters use LinkedIn as part of their candidate search.

Make sure that your LinkedIn profile is always up to date. Highlight your previous experience in detail and be comprehensive about your current skills and objectives. Also, be sure to use the option to flag your profile as available for work so potential employers and recruiters can find it easily. LinkedIn offers skill tests and colleague testimonials as well as other features, so spend time taking advantage of these. Remember to check local, state, and federal job sites as well. Find out whether your state employment agency hosts a job site and job fairs – these can be valuable resources.

You must create an account for most job websites to save job positions and search queries. You can also sign up for email alerts when new jobs are added in the fields you are interested in. Most sites use an applicant tracking system (ATS), which can make the job application process much easier to complete on the platform. It can also make it easier for recruiters to find candidates.

It's a good idea to research your field's industry leaders directly to see if you want to seek jobs with them. A strong starting point is to find the company's website and look for a Careers page. Look for jobs that interest you, see if you can create a profile and upload a resume so that their recruiters can find you. They may have a position that has not been listed yet.

While you're working on your Internet search, don't forget to connect with people who work at the companies you're applying to. By networking with people who work at companies you are considering working for, you get a better feel for the company culture. Networking is not only about trading information but also serves as an avenue to create long-term relationships with mutual benefits. Your new acquaintance may think of you when their team needs a new member.

To learn more about professionals in cybersecurity, check their postings and profile on LinkedIn, check bio pages on their companies' websites, search for news items about their work, and contact them to ask for an informational interview.

Whether you're a recent college graduate or a seasoned professional looking for a new opportunity, social media is a useful job search tool.

Ways to use social media for networking

Here are some ways to use social media effectively.

- Post about what kind of job you're looking for and that you are available.
- Find social media accounts of companies that interest you and follow them.
- Follow social media accounts of professional organizations in your field.
- Follow leading professionals.
- Participate in discussions online with these companies and organizations and ask questions.

A note of caution: Be aware of your social media accounts when you're looking for work. In the modern job search, companies may look up candidates on social media, so make sure there's nothing that might embarrass you if a potential employer sees it.

Offline networking

You can meet other professionals to network offline. Start by talking to your friends and meeting their friends. To extend your circle outward, there are many options. Some ideas are:

- Attend local meetups and interest groups for cybersecurity specialists or analysts. Check related topics at Meetup.com to find them.
- Join professional organizations and attend their meetings and events.
- Brush up your skills with adult education classes and talk to fellow students.
- Go to conferences for professionals in your field.
- Volunteer for organizations that can use your skills.

Wherever you go, speak to the people at the events. Practice introducing yourself. Don't ask new acquaintances for job leads directly until you know them better. If you learn to network well, they may bring it up even before you do.

Very often, getting a job is about who you know as much as what you know, so having someone to get you in the door can be a big benefit.



Skills Network